

United States History and Geography — Teacher Key

United States History and Geography · Tennessee Academic Standards 2027-28 · Form US-CORE-E

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classroom-formative · pre-field-test. Item parameters are estimates and have not met a student; this form is not a calibrated instrument. This is a selected-response form. It assesses Depth of Knowledge levels 1 through 3. It carries no extended-response item, so it does not assess DOK-4 — a four-option question cannot ask a student to construct and defend an argument. Extended responses and document-based questions are delivered as separate activities.

1. Which feature of the New Deal most directly led to the long-term transformation of the federal government's relationship to the American economy?

- A. The wartime production agreements that transferred factory ownership to the government
- B. The permanent regulatory agencies and social insurance programs that established ongoing federal economic oversight
- C. The diplomatic agreements with foreign nations that created international economic institutions
- D. The temporary relief programs that provided immediate aid but ended when the Depression subsided

KEY: B · DOK 2 · US.46

Why the key is right: The New Deal's lasting legacy was the creation of permanent institutions — the FDIC, SEC, Social Security, and federal labor standards — that fundamentally redefined the federal government as a manager and regulator of the American economy, a role it has retained ever since.

Item analysis

Standard

US.46 — Analyze the effects of and the controversies arising from New Deal economic policies, including charges of socialism and President Franklin D. Roosevelt's "court packing" attempt.

DOK / Hess

Level 2 — *no DOK rationale — the level is a number nobody justified*

Reporting category

— (source of record: UNMAPPED)

IRT

a 1.5 · b 0.8 · c 0.2 (pre-field-test — estimates, not calibrated against student responses)

Format

classroom-formative (tcapFormat: false — not affirmed — no human has judged this item field-testable)

Bias / sensitivity

not-started

Citation

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Historian review

not required

Distractor diagnosis

no misconception named — a distractor written to be merely wrong is noise, not diagnosis

2. A conservative senator in 1935 argues: 'The New Deal's programs will destroy American initiative by teaching citizens to depend on government handouts rather than their own labor.' An FDR supporter responds: 'Without government action, there is no labor market for initiative to operate in.' Which economic reasoning does the FDR supporter's response MOST effectively invoke?

- A. Government programs create a dependency culture only when they are permanent entitlements; temporary relief programs like the CCC and WPA maintained the work ethic by requiring labor in exchange for assistance.
- B. The conservative argument assumes that initiative produces economic growth in all conditions, but historically, periods of rapid government spending like wartime have produced more economic growth than periods of limited government.
- C. In a demand collapse, individual initiative cannot create employment because there are no buyers for the goods that initiative would produce — government must restore purchasing power before market mechanisms can function.
- D. Because the Depression was caused by overproduction rather than underproduction, the solution required reducing supply rather than stimulating demand, making government investment in job creation the economically correct response.

KEY: C · DOK 3 · US.46

Why the key is right: The FDR supporter's argument invokes Keynesian demand-side economics: in a severe demand collapse (like a depression), individual initiative cannot create jobs because there is no consumer demand for the goods that initiative would produce. Government spending must first restore demand before the market can create conditions in which individual initiative can operate. The conservative argument assumes a functioning market in which initiative can succeed; the New Deal argument says that without government intervention, the market has ceased to function, making individual initiative irrelevant. Students must identify the underlying economic framework of each argument.

Item analysis

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DOK / Hess

Level 3 — *no DOK rationale — the level is a number nobody justified*

Reporting category

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IRT

a 1.81 · b 1.36 · c 0.23 (pre-field-test — estimates, not calibrated against student responses)

Format

classroom-formative (tcapFormat: false — not affirmed — no human has judged this item field-testable)

Bias / sensitivity

not-started

Citation

—

Historian review

not required

Distractor diagnosis

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3. How did the Marshall Plan benefit the United States economically?

- A. It established American colonial territories and governing authority in Western Europe
- B. It forced European nations to pay war reparations directly to the United States
- C. It gave the U.S. direct control over valuable European natural resources and land
- D. It created markets for U.S. goods and developed strong trading partners in Europe

KEY: D · DOK 2 · US.60

Why the key is right: It created markets for U.S. goods and developed strong trading partners in Europe. Choice C is wrong because it describes it gave the U.S. direct control over valuable European natural resources and land, not it created markets for U.S. goods and developed strong trading partners in Europe. Containment committed the United States to long-term global leadership through aid, alliances, and military readiness.

Item analysis

Standard

US.60 — Analyze the Cold War policies of containment and the Truman Doctrine, Marshall Plan, and Berlin Airlift.

DOK / Hess

Level 2 — *no DOK rationale — the level is a number nobody justified*

Reporting category

— (source of record: UNMAPPED)

IRT

a 0.86 · b 0.46 · c 0.2 (pre-field-test — estimates, not calibrated against student responses)

Format

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Bias / sensitivity

not-started

Citation

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Historian review

not required

Distractor diagnosis

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4. Nixon's policy of détente with the Soviet Union represented a pragmatic shift in Cold War strategy. Which of the following best explains how détente differed from the earlier containment policy?

- A. Containment resisted Soviet expansion through confrontation and alliances; détente accepted Soviet power as a given and managed the rivalry through arms agreements and trade.
- B. Containment pursued formal diplomatic recognition of the Soviet Union, while détente relied on military coercion to limit Soviet influence.
- C. Détente abandoned opposition to Soviet expansion entirely, effectively permitting the USSR to absorb additional Eastern European satellite states.
- D. Détente aimed to eliminate nuclear weapons through comprehensive bilateral disarmament treaties negotiated directly between Nixon and Brezhnev.

KEY: A · DOK 3 · US.60

Why the key is right: Containment (Truman Doctrine) treated the Soviet Union as an adversary to be prevented from expanding, often through confrontational means. Détente, developed by Nixon and Kissinger, accepted Soviet power as a permanent reality and sought to manage the relationship through negotiated agreements (SALT I), trade linkage, and mutual recognition of spheres of influence—reducing the risk of direct military conflict. Option C conflates détente with appeasement. Option B incorrectly describes containment. Option D misrepresents détente's goals.

Item analysis

Standard

US.60 — Analyze the Cold War policies of containment and the Truman Doctrine, Marshall Plan, and Berlin Airlift.

DOK / Hess

Level 3 — *no DOK rationale — the level is a number nobody justified*

Reporting category

— (source of record: UNMAPPED)

IRT

a 2.19 · b 1.46 · c 0.25 (pre-field-test — estimates, not calibrated against student responses)

Format

classroom-formative (tcapFormat: false — not affirmed — no human has judged this item field-testable)

Bias / sensitivity

not-started

Citation

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Historian review

not required

Distractor diagnosis

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5. What was the significance of Linda Brown in the Brown v. Board case?

- A. They organized "respectable" resistance through economic pressure and political action
- B. She was the plaintiff whose case challenged school segregation in Topeka, Kansas
- C. To protect nine Black students integrating Central High School against mob violence
- D. Segregation psychologically harmed Black children and violated equal protection

KEY: B · DOK 1 · US.74

Why the key is right: Linda Brown was the Kansas student whose family joined the lawsuit challenging segregated schools in Topeka. Other choices are wrong if they describe lawyers or judges, because Brown was the child plaintiff at the center of the case. Her case gave a human face to the constitutional fight over equal education.

Item analysis

Standard

US.74 — Examine the decision and impacts of Brown v. Board of Education on the desegregation of schools, such as Scarboro 85, Clinton 12 and Little Rock 9. (T.C.A. § 49-6-1006)

DOK / Hess

Level 1 — *no DOK rationale — the level is a number nobody justified*

Reporting category

— (source of record: UNMAPPED)

IRT

a 0.88 · b -0.94 · c 0.23 (pre-field-test — estimates, not calibrated against student responses)

Format

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Citation

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Historian review

not required

Distractor diagnosis

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6. Which factor best explains why Linda Brown's case became the lead case in the Supreme Court's landmark 1954 desegregation ruling?

- A. Linda Brown was the only plaintiff whose family had directly experienced violence as a result of school segregation policies
- B. Linda Brown's school had uniquely inferior facilities that made the harm of segregation easier to prove in court
- C. The NAACP consolidated multiple desegregation cases from different states, and Brown's case from Kansas led the docket because it challenged segregation in a non-Southern state
- D. The Brown case had already been decided in the plaintiff's favor at the district court level, giving it the strongest legal foundation

KEY: C · DOK 2 · US.74

Why the key is right: The NAACP combined five cases from Kansas, South Carolina, Virginia, Delaware, and Washington D.C. Placing a Kansas case first strategically undermined the defense that segregation was uniquely a Southern custom.

Item analysis

Standard

US.74 — Examine the decision and impacts of Brown v. Board of Education on the desegregation of schools, such as Scarboro 85, Clinton 12 and Little Rock 9. (T.C.A. § 49-6-1006)

DOK / Hess

Level 2 — *no DOK rationale — the level is a number nobody justified*

Reporting category

— (source of record: UNMAPPED)

IRT

a 1.2 · b 0.5 · c 0.2 (pre-field-test — estimates, not calibrated against student responses)

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Bias / sensitivity

not-started

Citation

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Historian review

not required

Distractor diagnosis

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7. What was the role of Diane Nash in the civil rights movement?

- A. She refused to give up her bus seat in Montgomery, Alabama in 1955
- B. She led the SCLC's Birmingham Campaign and was arrested with Dr. King
- C. She was the first African American woman to serve on the U.S. Supreme Court
- D. She led Nashville sit-ins and was a key organizer of the Freedom Rides

KEY: D · DOK 1 · US.76

Why the key is right: Diane Nash was a key student leader in the Nashville sit-ins and helped keep the Freedom Rides going after early mob attacks. Choices naming her as the founder of SNCC or the trigger of the bus boycott are wrong because her leadership was centered in student direct action. She represents the crucial role of young organizers in the movement.

Item analysis

Standard

US.76 — Examine the roles and actions of civil rights advocates (e.g., Dr. Martin Luther King, Jr., Malcolm X, John Lewis, Diane Nash, Thurgood Marshall, Rosa Parks) and opponents (e.g., Bull Connor, Orval Faubus, George Wallace, Strom Thurmond). (T.C.A. § 49-6-1006)

DOK / Hess

Level 1 — *no DOK rationale — the level is a number nobody justified*

Reporting category

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IRT

a 0.91 · b 0.37 · c 0.22 (pre-field-test — estimates, not calibrated against student responses)

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Citation

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Historian review

not required

Distractor diagnosis

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8. How did Strom Thurmond's political career reflect the shifts in Southern white opposition to civil rights between the 1940s and 1960s?

- A. Thurmond ran for president as a Dixiecrat in 1948 opposing civil rights, filibustered the 1957 Civil Rights Act for over 24 hours, and later switched to the Republican Party
- B. Thurmond began as a supporter of civil rights legislation and later became disillusioned after the failure of the Civil Rights Act
- C. Thurmond supported President Truman's desegregation of the military while opposing integration of public schools
- D. Thurmond's opposition to civil rights was based primarily on economic arguments about the cost of desegregation rather than racial ideology

KEY: A · DOK 2 · US.76

Why the key is right: Thurmond's 1948 Dixiecrat presidential run (NARA, 1948 Electoral College Results — 39 EVs), record Senate filibuster of civil rights legislation, and 1964 switch to the Republican Party (Senate.gov, "Senators Who Changed Parties During Senate Service" — September 16, 1964) trace the transformation of Southern white politics in response to federal civil rights pressure.

Item analysis

Standard

US.76 — Examine the roles and actions of civil rights advocates (e.g., Dr. Martin Luther King, Jr., Malcolm X, John Lewis, Diane Nash, Thurgood Marshall, Rosa Parks) and opponents (e.g., Bull Connor, Orval Faubus, George Wallace, Strom Thurmond). (T.C.A. § 49-6-1006)

DOK / Hess

Level 2 — *no DOK rationale — the level is a number nobody justified*

Reporting category

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IRT

a 1.3 · b 0.4 · c 0.2 (pre-field-test — estimates, not calibrated against student responses)

Format

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Bias / sensitivity

not-started

Citation

—

Historian review

not required

Distractor diagnosis

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9. How did the 24th Amendment (1964) address one specific barrier to voting that had been used to disenfranchise poor and minority voters?

- A. It guaranteed the right of all citizens over 21 to vote regardless of race, expanding on the Fifteenth Amendment's more limited protections
- B. It abolished the poll tax in federal elections, eliminating a fee that had prevented many poor African Americans and poor whites in the South from voting
- C. It lowered the voting age to 18, expanding the electorate by including young adults who had been disenfranchised
- D. It prohibited literacy tests in all state and federal elections, removing the most common disenfranchisement tool used against Black voters

KEY: B · DOK 2 · US.78

Why the key is right: The 24th Amendment abolished poll taxes in federal elections. Poll taxes had been used since Reconstruction as an economic barrier to disenfranchise Black voters and poor whites. Section 10 of the Voting Rights Act of 1965 directed the Attorney General to challenge state poll taxes; the Supreme Court abolished them in *Harper v. Virginia State Board of Elections*, 383 U.S. 663 (1966).

Item analysis

Standard

US.78 — Analyze civil and voting rights legislation, including the Civil Rights Act of 1964, the Voting Rights Act of 1965, the Civil Rights Act of 1968 (i.e., Fair Housing Act), and the 24th Amendment. (T.C.A. § 49-6-1006)

DOK / Hess

Level 2 — *no DOK rationale — the level is a number nobody justified*

Reporting category

— (source of record: UNMAPPED)

IRT

a 1.1 · b -0.3 · c 0.2 (pre-field-test — estimates, not calibrated against student responses)

Format

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Bias / sensitivity

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Citation

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Historian review

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Distractor diagnosis

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10. The Voting Rights Act of 1965 outlawed literacy tests and provided for federal oversight of elections in jurisdictions with histories of discriminatory practices. Congress reauthorized the Act by large bipartisan majorities multiple times before the Supreme Court's 2013 *Shelby County v. Holder* decision struck down the coverage formula. How does this legislative history most clearly illustrate the contested nature of voting rights enforcement in American democracy?

A. The repeated bipartisan reauthorizations demonstrate that genuine national consensus around racial equality in voting had emerged by the 1970s, making *Shelby County* an anomalous departure from American democracy's settled commitment to universal franchise rather than a continuation of contested historical patterns.

B. The VRA's history shows that once landmark legislation creates powerful political constituencies, those constituencies generate sufficient political pressure to sustain the legislation indefinitely, making democratic mobilization a more reliable protection for voting rights than constitutional litigation.

C. The VRA's repeated reauthorization demonstrates that active federal enforcement mechanisms — not merely formal legal prohibitions — are necessary for voting rights to function in practice, because Congress reauthorized the preclearance requirement specifically because conditions justifying structural protection persisted, while *Shelby County* illustrates the risks of removing those mechanisms based on evidence of improvement rather than elimination

D. The *Shelby County* decision correctly recognized that the VRA's geographic coverage formula had become outdated, since the dramatic documented improvements in Black voter registration in covered Southern states proved that the law had accomplished its intended purpose and that preclearance requirements were no longer proportionate to existing conditions.

KEY: C · DOK 3 · US.78

Why the key is right: The VRA's legislative history illustrates that voting rights protection is not self-sustaining once formally enacted: Congress's repeated findings in reauthorization proceedings that discriminatory conditions persisted demonstrated the need for ongoing structural enforcement, while *Shelby County*'s removal of preclearance based on measurable improvement was followed by documented evidence of new restrictive measures in previously covered jurisdictions.

Item analysis

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US.78 — Analyze civil and voting rights legislation, including the Civil Rights Act of 1964, the Voting Rights Act of 1965, the Civil Rights Act of 1968 (i.e., Fair Housing Act), and the 24th Amendment. (T.C.A. § 49-6-1006)

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Reporting category

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IRT

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Format

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